

James Robinson
Acadia University
EDUC 42D3 SU02
Principles and Practices
Summer 2026

My Why

If there is one thing that I have learned about teaching through observation, the experience of being a student, and, more recently, taking a look behind the proverbial curtain into the theory and mechanics of working in education, it is that the identity of “teacher” extends well beyond that of an occupation, past the classroom walls, and plays a definitive role reaching out into every corner of a teacher’s life and selfhood. Hence, the question of why must also extend outwards; it cannot be captured entirely in a simple mission statement nor mathematically deduced from the results of an aptitude test. To get to the heart of my why of teaching, I must reflect on the core of my being; the values that make up my moral foundation, the experiences that have moulded my worldview, and the idealized version of myself that I aspire to become.

To begin, there is a clear and somewhat concise logical progression, at least in hindsight, of the circumstances and events which led me here: 24 years old, living in Nova Scotia, back at Acadia starting an education degree two years after graduating with my Bachelor of Computer Science. I view this more as the “how” than the “why” to my decision to pursue teaching, but it lays the groundwork for deeper reflection.

Both of my parents worked for most of their careers in roles more or less adjacent to teaching. They met working in a youth care facility in Calgary. My dad stayed in that line of work up until a few years before his retirement, across facilities and provinces, my mom took on a greater range of opportunities, starting a daycare before my brothers and I were in school and building a career in Nova Scotia as an educational assistant which led her to work with Schools Plus and her current role specializing in resources and behaviour management. My parents modeled for me the importance of serving a community, of working to provide opportunities to kids who would otherwise go without, and the lasting fulfillment of a values-driven career. When I was searching for a career change, I looked to their example and decided that teaching was where I could make an impact like they had.

I always felt comfortable and capable in the classroom, more so, perhaps, than anywhere else. My earliest memories of school are of praise from my teachers and classmates for being the first to finish a task, for always being ready with the right answer, or for guiding someone else to understanding a topic. As this continued through my academic career, I was encouraged towards the more advanced streams – first French Immersion, then later the IB program – and I was also able to explore and devote time to a number of other activities based out of the school from soccer teams to musicals to student council and everything in between. I met every new challenge without issue; no matter what else was going on around me, school stayed relatively straightforward and easy. With this in mind, it only makes sense that I should find myself wanting to get back to the classroom, where I was most sure of myself and my role.

I could list at length the teachers who inspired me with their devotion, pedagogical prowess, and authentic interest in me. As a student who excelled with the curriculum material and was ever eager to please, I think it was easier for me than most to see the best in my teachers and appreciate the effort they put in. There were teachers who did everything to make sure that their classroom was a welcoming and fun place to learn, who came in every day with enthusiasm and made sure every student left feeling seen and valued, teachers who seemed to have an endless well of time and energy to pour into extracurriculars, teachers who so obviously had a mastery of their field and wanted everyone else to share in that appreciation, and teachers who could somehow see depths of potential in me waiting to be realized and challenge me when they knew I could do better. With their examples, the idea of what it can mean to be a teacher and the meaningful impact teachers can have has expanded to encompass so much more than what gets covered in a textbook.

To this day I have spent more time, cumulatively, working at summer camps than in any other setting. I loved getting to know a group of campers each week, building up relationships and doing my part to make sure they all had a safe, fun, and enriching experience. In later years, I was able to do some work planning and running events alongside managing the day-to-day interactions which added another layer to my engagement in the process and the satisfaction that came with seeing the impact on campers. These experiences started forming my understanding of what feels like a good day's work and what motivates me to get up and do my best each day. In some ways, moving from software engineering to teaching was less of a hard pivot than it was a return to form.

When I was studying computer science, I felt myself drawn to engaging with the community of learners I found myself in as much as the course material. As much as I still loved being a student I also sought out opportunities to tutor and coordinate events with the computer science society, to act as a point of contact for campus resources as an RA, to TA, and to run a series of game development workshops. I got excited by sharing knowledge with other students.

During this time, I was also finding out what kinds of work failed to inspire that same excitement. It felt good to help people out with troubleshooting and tips for using their computer as an IT assistant, but handling tickets was not really challenging or creatively stimulating enough for me to want to make a career out of it. Working in software development, both as a summer internship and after graduating, was fantastic for providing creative problems, but at the end of the day solving those problems did not feel like enough if the overarching goal was to impress a group of investors or deliver what the client wanted cheaper and faster than anyone else. I wanted the fulfillment of having a tangible, positive impact on not only individuals but my community and society at large. One thing that is never said about teachers, at least in my experience, is that they are not making a difference.

It would be dishonest of me to deny or downplay the fact that these software jobs were not the flashy, six-figure positions that were at one point the presupposed destination of any bright kid who was willing to learn to code – the job market for software engineers is in a rough spot and has been for a few years now. Although I cannot answer with certainty, the question imposes itself: would I still be pursuing teaching if I had been more successful in my previous career or if the profession was not, as it seems to be now, a relatively sure and stable path to secure, long-term employment? Whether or not I would have chosen to trade a flashier, better compensated job for the gratification of teaching, I can honestly say that the path I am on now aligns more closely with the values I profess and the kind of person I want to be.

As someone who always wants as much information as possible before making any decision, let alone one that stands to alter the trajectory of the rest of my life, I had to at least try substituting before fully committing to an education degree. It was a terrible start. My first day working in a high school I found myself in an English 10 class that made it their goal to be as disruptive as possible along with a student teacher older and more experienced than me who I wanted to avoid overstepping, but who had as little control over the classroom behaviour as I did. I made it through that period and found some small success helping a different class work through compound interest calculations. At the end of the day, the vice

principal thanked me for coming in, asked what I would most like to teach, and invited me back the next day. I won't go so far as to pretend that I was immediately hooked on teaching and suddenly sure of my path forward, but it was enough to go back the next day and each day gave me another reason to keep coming back until I found myself feeling bittersweet when the time came to move back to Wolfville.

While all of the experiences discussed above demonstrate the ways I have discovered why teaching feels right to me, I believe that the "why" lies deeper still in the foundational values, shaped by my experiences but also whatever inherent selfhood that makes me who I am, that guide me in what I feel makes a good, worthwhile career. I believe in the transcendent value of learning to individuals and communities, I believe that every person has the ability, given the proper time, resources, and support, to succeed in any given pursuit, and I believe that inclusion in a supportive community is a foundational need for all people and the best way to improve global society.

Obviously, I would not be pursuing an education degree if I did not believe in the importance of learning. To be more specific, I do not value learning as a means to an end nearly as much as I believe in learning for its own sake. To value learning as a mere tool, an implement by which one can improve one's lot in life or otherwise accomplish an external, tangible goal, is to tie its worth implicitly to markets and capital and to position knowledge as a tactical advantage in a zero-sum game within a world full of competitors. With modern technological advancements students may ask: if machines can do everything, why learn anything? No answer that relies on what learning will do for you is, in my view, sufficient. I value learning, and thereby the role of teachers, instead as connecting the learner with a universality of human kind, stretching across space and time. To seek to understand, to explore and find meaning is an integral and ubiquitous part of being a person and I want to, through teaching, ensure that this pursuit is treasured and cultivated in students instead of being discouraged for the sake of developing more efficient workers.

When I say I believe in the ability of everyone to experience success when properly supported, I include the belief that facilitating that success is an appropriate and actionable goal by the education system. While my beliefs are my own, this in particular is inextricably linked to my parents' values and work; their example showed me what it means to see and value each individual and the importance of making sure everyone has someone who believes in their potential. I was aware of classmates who were struggling in school with things I found easy, my parents made sure that I knew these kids were not flawed or deficient, but instead had been failed at some point by the system I fit into so easily. By

pursuing teaching, I hope that I can not only pass this message along but also fight, as my parents have, to remove those barriers and pitfalls that left so many kids behind.

I have already touched on my belief in the ability of teachers to have an impact beyond what happens at school or in the classroom, that community, support, and an authentic interest in students can be more meaningful than anything covered in the curriculum. I believe that everyone has both a need and a responsibility to belong and contribute to some form of community and that teachers have the further responsibility of modelling how positive, supportive communities function and fostering an appreciation of interreliance in their students. I am pursuing teaching because I want to make sure that every student knows the feeling of being in community, learns to value it, and carries it with them out into the world. At a time that everything seems to be moving towards the insular and individualistic, I want to give students an alternative where everyone's personhood and contributions can be recognized.

My reasons for wanting to pursue teaching as a career are personal, complex, and varied, but if I were to sum them all up into a single sentiment it would be this: who I am is in line with and connected to teaching, and what I value in teaching reflects who I want to be. My experiences, guided by my values, have brought me this far and I am confident that they can keep carrying me down this path, wherever it may end up taking me.